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The Best (and Worst) of UCI's Undergrad On-Campus Housing

BY ORDER OF THE PHOENIX

Perhaps one of the most agonizing and treacherous decisions a student will make during their college career surrounds housing. How livable one's dorm is can determine everything—studies show that the quality of a residence hall significantly impacts a student's mental wellbeing and subsequently, grade point average. Whether they know it or not, the choice of on-campus housing can shape a student's future.

Here at UCI, undergraduates have five options to choose from. In order of the date they were constructed from oldest to newest, they are: Mesa Court Classics, Middle Earth

Classics, Mesa Court Towers, Middle Earth Towers, and the ACC Apartments.

I don't live in student housing, and never have. I live with my parents off-campus. This, of course, begs the question: in what way am I qualified to settle the debate that has persisted on the UCI subreddit and lunchtime discussions at UTC- the debate on which on-campus housing community is the best?

My experience (or lack thereof) with student housing belies the fact that I am in fact the perfect candidate to put an end to this discussion for once and for all. Untainted by bias, and armed purely with my own observations, conversations with student residents, and my invariably correct opinions, this is my comprehensive ranking that will surely answer the age-old question: Which undergraduate housing community here at UCI reigns supreme? And, as we're about to see, why is it not Mesa Court Classics?

Which brings us nicely to...

#5- Mesa Court Classics

It's immediately apparent that the Mesa Court Classics buildings lag far behind the other on-campus options. Everything about these buildings, from the wooden and stucco siding on the exterior to the furniture of the ground floor common areas, is notably dated. It should come as no surprise, then, that the Mesa Court Classics community dates back to UCI's founding- 1965.

Amirdeep, a second-year from India, has lived in both a single-occupancy room in a Mesa Court Classics hall and a quadruple-occupancy room in the Towers. He was more than happy to give up his spacious Classics room, even if it meant sharing a room with three other people.

"It's not nice in there, man. There's supposed to be a cleaning staff but they don't clean, and the whole floor shares a bathroom." Amirdeep said. For his hall, that was seven people to one bathroom. "I was honestly so glad to get out of there."

Amirdeep's friend, Jerry, isn't as lucky, The rooms themselves, while livable, also aren't quite as modernized as their newer counterparts. As I enter Jerry's room, my eyes are immediately assaulted by the large fluorescent light panels that belong in a classroom rather than a dorm room, fixed to

the popcorn ceiling. They cast a glossy, radiant glow on the worn carpet, as well as the radiator with chipped paint that looks like it hasn't been touched since the building was constructed.

The bathroom is even worse. Drab gray tile flooring, which is mildly damp when I enter, along with shower walls covered in a film of mildew, has me retreating as soon as I take a cursory glance at the facilities. It would barely be passable were it a public restroom.

So, what do the Mesa Court Classics halls have going for them?

"Community," Amirdeep responds. "The newer halls, like the towers, aren't so great for mingling. With the classics, people would befriend their neighbors, [and] hang out in the common areas. You don't really get that at the towers."

Perhaps the real dorm is the friends we made along the way.

#4- Middle Earth Classics

The Middle Earth Classics were built a decade after their cross-campus counterparts, and it seems the designers learned from their previous mistakes. The sienna stucco has weathered the years much better, and these walls also contain something that their predecessors lacked—personality.

Instead of residence halls with uninspiring names like 'Isla', 'Arroyo', 'Ciela', words which would much rather belong on a vocab sheet in an intro to Spanish class, Middle Earth's residence halls sport names like 'Shadowfax', 'Oakenshield', and 'Misty Mountain'. That alone might be enough to get any prospective UCI applicants excited about the campus culture, given they're big enough of a nerd.

And when it comes to the facilities themselves, there's much less murmurs of discontent among the ranks of the residents at the Middle Earth Classics, too. Despite the dated furniture on par with those at Mesa Court, the bathrooms seem well taken care of, and rooms seem updated with newer carpets, as well as wider windows that let in a great amount of natural light.

Spiro Sun is a third-year who's called Middle Earth Classics home for the past year. Like many of its residents, he's had a middling living experience.

"To be honest, it's a lot less modernized than I expected," Sun says, having got a brief taste of some of the other halls on offer at UCI. "I also visited the towers for SPOP (Student Parent Orientation Program) and those rooms looked a lot nicer. But I can't complain because it could be a lot worse, too."

With single- and double-occupancy rooms, the Classics represent the most expensive option on-campus. According to Sun, those living in single-occupancy rooms can expect to pay upwards of an eye-watering \$5,500 per quarter.

Luckily, for those who aren't keen on selling away their firstborn son to the University of California system, things get better.

#3- ACC Apartments

“Living in the apartments is basically just like living in any other apartment building. The only difference is that all of your neighbors go to school with you,” says Jessica Yang, a third-year who was lucky enough to navigate through the infamous housing application portal and come out the other side with a spot in the Camino del Sol community, one of six designed and managed by American Campus Communities—the largest such company in the country.

Many residents are a fan of this alternative way of on-campus living as opposed to dorms. Their concerns pale in comparison to the ones fielded from the Mesa Court Classics students. The rooms don't quite match the pictures on the UCI Housing website— but when does the product ever match the advertisement? The rooms are dusty on move-in day, but that's nothing a few wet wipes can't fix. And while the wifi is prone to instability, students make do with cellular data hotspots whenever outages occur.

Perhaps it was the effect that touring manky, grimy residence halls in the Classics for three hours had on me, but the rooms that I peek my head into at Camino del Sol seem like a resplendent oasis of comfort. Hardwood flooring, sleek furnishings included with the room, air conditioning

(something even the new towers can't boast) and bathrooms that don't look like they could be found in Dante's description of the nine circles of hell mark a welcome change in quality. Amenities such as a fitness center, outdoor kitchen area and even a pool complete with cabanas truly do make me feel, as the community boasts on its website, that I've 'never lived like this'.

But according to research from Dr. Joshua Brown, who conducted a study with the University of Virginia concerning dorm design and its impact on students, there may be an unintended consequence to the way these apartments have been constructed.

"There is a social cost associated with apartment-style residence halls as opposed to the traditional layout." Dr. Brown says. "The apartment-style focus on privacy renders them more isolating to students and lessens opportunities for social interaction." It is this 'social cost', he explains, that leads to higher rates of loneliness that have measurable impacts on academic performance- around a tenth of a grade point according to his data.

This theory is further supported by conversations with Camino del Sol's undergraduate residents. "I definitely don't talk with my roommates much. [I] just [go] into my room immediately after I come home from class," Yang explains. "I don't even know who my neighbors are, honestly."

#2- Middle Earth Towers

The Towers, despite their modern appearance and recent construction, luckily don't suffer from the design flaws outlined by Dr. Brown's research. The five-level low-rise, boasting a facade of sparkling glass, concrete and exposed steel, lines up its dorm rooms side-by-side flanking a central hallway. Each floor has its own laundry area and study facilities, making it easier still for students to interact with one another.

The rooms also look spacious and livable. Tall floor-to-ceiling windows ensure that residents are at little risk of experiencing shortages of Vitamin D, and every housing unit has its own bathroom, kept fresh and clean while having enough space for the four to eight students that will share it.

The designers also haven't neglected the *Lord of the Rings*-themed touches that graced the Classic residence halls. Inscriptions of Tolkien's Elvish language have been carved into the towers' concrete base, while high-tech learning spaces bearing names such as 'Gandalf's Classroom' join other amenities such as a gym and dining hall, Brandywine.

Now that we've narrowed down the winner to either one of the Towers, what separates Middle Earth and Mesa Court in this narrow two-horse race?

#1- Mesa Court Towers

My awarding the top spot to the Mesa Court Towers is predicated on two points- dining and social life.

As every student who resides in the residence halls is contractually obliged to obtain a meal plan, the food quality at the dining halls is a crucial factor in my decision. To see for myself which hall is better I dropped a combined \$34 on guest entry fees for Middle Earth's Brandywine and Mesa Court's Anteater, and I'm still angry about it.

The food on offer can only be described as typical buffet fare, except worse. I get the same lunch at both halls on different days, and by a slim margin, the Anteater has my vote. The pepperoni pizza at Brandywine is warm but very dry, like I've left it in the box overnight. The spaghetti is mushy and the pasta clearly overcooked. The only thing I know how to do in a kitchen is bug my mother about when dinner will be finished, and even I can still boil pasta *al dente*, or at least better than what was put on my plate. Anteater, by comparison, is passable. The fact that students are forking over four figures per quarter for this, though, is enough to make me feel physically ill.

But conversations with diners at the Anteater, including friend groups with students dorming at both Mesa Court and Middle Earth Towers, does elucidate me about the decisive point that wins top spot for the former- the social scene.

"The Middle Earth [Towers] social scene is dead," third-year Tej Thakur says. "I mean, it probably has to do with the fact that it's all introverted STEM students, but people just stick to themselves most of the time."

Tej's friend and Mesa Court Towers resident Daniel is quick to chime in. "The atmosphere at Mesa Court [towers] is awesome. The RAs really make an effort to make sure people get along, and the events are nice. People show up for them."

The fact that Mesa Court Towers only offers quadruple-occupancy rooms doesn't seem to give any of its residents any cause for complaint- any issues I do hear seem to be related to bad roommates rather than the room itself. The rooms are spacious enough to house four people, and the facilities well-equipped to handle them. And as Dr. Brown explains, socialization is important for success, something the Mesa Court Towers can offer in abundance.

So, at the end of it all, it's the Mesa Court Towers that rules the roost. With clean rooms, useful amenities, sociable neighbors and better food (just), the Mesa Court Towers are hereby declared UCI's best on-campus housing for undergrads.

I'll still take my comfy little room in my parents' house over all that any day, though.

UCI On-Campus Undergrad Housing Ranked				
	PRO		CON	
1	Great social life, clean and updated rooms, better dining hall, useful amenities		No on-site gym, kitchen facilities not cleaned often enough	MESA COURT TOWERS
2	Spacious rooms, great bathrooms, close to STEM buildings and UTC		No social life, bad dining hall	MIDDLE EARTH TOWERS
3	Furnishings included, fantastic amenities, hassle-free, regular cleaning		Unreliable wi-fi, isolating design leading to poorer academic performance	ACC APARTMENTS
4	Themed housing with personality, decent rooms and bathrooms, single-occupancy rooms on offer		Mediocre social life, not good value for money	MIDDLE EARTH CLASSICS
5	Amazing social life, single-occupancy rooms on offer		Dated rooms, bad bathrooms, overburdened facilities, not good value for money	MESA COURT CLASSICS

Author's Note

Housing information from:

<https://www.housing.uci.edu>

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https://oac.cdlib.org/findaid/ark:/13030/kt7580290j/entire_text/

ACC information from:

<https://www.statista.com/statistics/934609/student-housing-owners-by-number-of-properties-usa/>

Study on dorm layout and academic performance from:

<https://www.insidehighered.com/news/2019/06/21/study-shows-how-different-types-college-dormitories-can-affect-grades>

<https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/19496591.2019.1611590?scroll=top&needAccess=true>

Meal plan information from:

Dining Options



UCI Student Housing

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